

even larger number rejected the idea of political and civic equality for Black people.

Occasionally, Northerners showed their hostility toward abolitionists by attacking them physically. Between 1834 and 1838, approximately 30 such attacks occurred. Buildings were torched, newspaper presses destroyed, and abolitionist speakers were shouted down and roughed up. Many of the attacks were organized by political and business leaders trying to prove to Southerners that abolitionists were just a deluded minority. However, in Alton, Illinois, one attack proved fatal. Elijah Lovejoy moved to St. Louis in 1834 to serve as a Presbyterian minister and publisher of a religious newspaper in whose pages he advocated abolition. After witnessing an enslaved person burned alive at the stake, Lovejoy condemned slavery, the legal system, and the thousands who had joined the mob. His press was destroyed in 1836 and he moved across the river to Alton where he set up the *Alton Observer*. His anti-slavery editorials angered many of Alton's citizens, who attacked his office three times and destroyed his presses. In November, 1837, Lovejoy and about 20 men were gathered to hide and protect a new press from a mob when shots were exchanged and Lovejoy was killed.

Yet brutal mob violence, Southern condemnation, and Federal acceptance of censorship of the mail and right of petition failed to halt the growing spread of anti-slavery and abolition societies. Attacks and attempts to limit freedom of speech troubled a Northern public that had so far been indifferent or opposed to abolitionists' goals. Issues about the expansion of slavery and a growing sectional rift over the place of slavery in the West and in the nation made hostile Northerners listen again to abolitionist critiques of the South.